

didn't need. We all know how that worked out. Even stores that don't employ disarming design tactics still use strategic spatial arrangements in their displays to encourage impulse buying.

As a mother of young children, I rarely shopped at Gap stores, even though I truly love their soft cotton outfits and girl's decorated socks and underpants. Except for the slashed clearance prices, their clothes were just too pricey. When I did visit one, I headed straight toward the clearance racks. It didn't matter what mall I frequented, the racks were always located in the same place—in a corner at the back wall. After I'd gathered my sale items and began navigating back towards the checkout counter, I'd inevitably be confronted by signs that were turned to face customers coming from that end of the store. Once I reached the counter, I would be greeted with yet more signage offering additional savings if I signed up for their store credit card, and occasionally, a bin or display of a lower-priced items that hadn't been moving off the shelves fast enough.

None of this is done by accident. It is all part of a marketing strategy devised by someone who has studied consumer behavior. Strategic placement of sale racks and signs is all part of the store's marketing plan, which is designed specifically to entice the shopper to purchase more. The sale-priced merchandise is located in the back so price-conscious consumers, like me, have to navigate the entire store to get to it and the signs are turned so they catch the eye on the way back to the checkout. From the time a consumer sets foot in a store until the second they leave, forces of behavioral psychology and marketing ploys are at work, increasing the odds that shoppers will stay longer and buy more. Even